Sahulatcart

The plan to make it a product people can buy

12 October 2026

What this document is

This is the one plan for finishing Sahulatcart. It says what we build, in what order, and what happens on the day Meta approves us.
It is written in plain words. Technical terms are explained in the glossary on the last page. The version for engineers, with file names and API calls, is docs/launch/PLAN.md in the code.

The big idea

We build the whole product now, and test it using Meta's test setup. On the day Meta approves us, the only work is changing three settings. No new code.
This works because Meta approval does not give us any new tools. It only changes **who** we are allowed to use the same tools for. Before approval: our own test number and a few merchants we add as testers. After approval: anyone.

1. Where we are today

Checked against the live system on 12 October 2026.

Working now, used by real customers

- The sales bot: talks in Roman Urdu, finds the product, bargains within the price limits the merchant sets, answers questions about the shop, understands voice notes, suggests add-ons, and hands over to a human when needed.
- Orders: cash on delivery, and bank transfer with a screenshot the merchant checks.
- The merchant portal: dashboard, inbox (with take-over), orders, product catalog (with CSV and Shopify import, and AI-written descriptions), settings, notifications, sales figures.
- Behind the scenes: messages are never lost, stock is reserved properly, daily backups run.

Live data today: 1 merchant, 5 products, 2 conversations, 0 orders. We have not started the pilot yet.

Built for one shop only

Incoming messages already go to the right merchant. But every **outgoing** message uses one password-like key stored in a settings file. There is no sign-up page, no "Connect WhatsApp" button, and a new merchant can only be added by hand.

Missing completely

What	Why it matters
Sign-up and "Connect WhatsApp"	A merchant cannot join on their own.
One key per merchant	Needed so each shop sends from its own number safely.
Pre-approved messages (templates)	If a buyer last wrote more than 24 hours ago, the bot cannot message them at all today.
Alerts outside the portal	A merchant only sees a new order while the portal is open.
Order stages after "paid"	No "packed", "sent", "delivered".
Billing	No plans, no trial, no way to charge merchants.

The real blocker is paperwork, not code

The Meta roadmap from September asked for six things from the owner by 26 September. They are still open: NTN certificate, full street address, the legal name copied exactly from the certificate, Gemini billing switched on, a dedicated SIM, a card on the Meta account.
The website still shows "To be confirmed" for the NTN and address. Nothing on the Meta side can start until these exist. See section 7.

2. What Meta approval changes

Most people think approval unlocks new features. It does not. Here is what actually changes:

	Before approval (now)	After approval
App status	Development	Live
Who can connect a number	Our test number, plus merchants we add as "testers"	Any merchant
Messages allowed	250 per day per business	Grows with good behaviour
The tools we use	Same	Same
Our code	Same	Same

So we build and test everything with testers first, send Meta the two short videos it asks for as soon as those features work, and keep building while Meta reviews.

Approval day: the whole job

1. In the Meta dashboard, switch the app from **Development** to **Live**.
2. Check that the two permissions show **Advanced access**.
3. In Railway, set **SIGNUP_OPEN = true**. Until then, only emails on our list can sign up.
4. One real merchant signs up, connects their number, and sends one message.

That is all. Everything else in this plan happens before that day.

3. Two tracks, side by side

Track A is the Meta paperwork. It is mostly waiting, and only the owner can start it. **Track B** is building the product. The two meet once: Meta's review (A6) needs the first two product milestones (B1 and B2) working, because Meta wants a video of the real thing.

Weeks	Track A: Meta	Track B: Product
1	A1 Owner sends the paperwork. A2 We publish it on the website.	B1 Sign-up and Connect WhatsApp
2-3	A3 Business verification (waiting on Meta)	B1 continues
4	A4 Set up the Meta app. A5 Join the Tech Provider programme. A6 Send App Review.	B2 Pre-approved messages. Record the two videos.
5-6	A6 Meta reviews (about a day, but allow slack)	B3 Onboarding that checks everything before going live
7-8	A7 Approval day (if all went well)	B4 What a real shop needs in its first week
9-10		B5 Making it safe for many shops
11-13		B6 Pilot with 3 to 5 real shops
14		B7 Billing

If Meta is slower than this, Track B keeps going; nothing after B2 waits for Meta. If Meta is faster, the pilot starts earlier with real merchants instead of testers.

4. Track A: Meta, step by step

Step	Who	What happens	How long
A1 Paperwork	Owner	Send the six items in section 7.	This week
A2 Website	Engineering	Put the NTN, street address and exact legal name on the About page and in every footer. Meta compares the website with the documents letter by letter.	Same day
A3 Business verification	Owner submits, Meta decides	In Meta Business Manager: type the business details exactly as on the certificate, upload the two documents, confirm a code by phone or email. Then wait. Never resubmit with changed details.	Hours to a few days
A4 Meta app setup	Engineering, with the owner logged in	Create the app, attach it to the verified business, fill in the basic settings (icon, privacy, terms, data-deletion pages), create the "Connect WhatsApp" configuration, and turn on four webhook alerts (messages, template status, number quality, account changes). Today only one of the four is on.	Half a day
A5 Tech Provider	Owner	Accept Meta's platform terms in the developer dashboard.	Minutes

Step	Who	What happens	How long
A6 App Review	Engineering prepares, owner submits	Ask for exactly two permissions (sending messages, managing accounts). For each: a short written reason and one uncut screen recording of the real product. Needs B1 and B2 done.	About a day for Meta
A7 Approval day	Owner and engineering	The four steps in section 2.	An hour

If Meta is slow

The old plan had no fallback. There is one. Numbers that belong to **our** verified business can send messages without the extra approval. For the pilot we can give each shop a Sahulatcart-owned number with the shop's name on it.
This is a stopgap, not the product: Meta expects a number's display name to match the business that owns it. The shop moves to its own number as soon as approval lands, and we build the connect button so that move is a reconnect, not a migration.

5. Track B: Product, milestone by milestone

Each milestone has one pass-or-fail test. It is not done until that test passes on the live system, not just on a laptop.

B1. Sign-up and "Connect WhatsApp" (3 weeks)

What we build. A sign-up page with email and password, email confirmation and password reset. The first login creates the shop automatically. A "Connect WhatsApp" button that opens Meta's own connection window; when the merchant finishes, we store their key safely (encrypted, never shown in the browser), link their number to their shop, and send one test message. A page that shows whether the number is connected, its quality rating, and buttons to reconnect or disconnect.

Why. This is the heart of self-service, and the first thing Meta wants to see in the review video.

Done when: A tester signs up, connects the test number, sends a message and gets a bot reply. A second tester cannot see or use the first tester's number.

B2. Pre-approved messages (templates) (1 week)

What we build. When a shop connects, we automatically create three pre-approved messages on its account: "order confirmed", "payment verified", "payment rejected". A page shows whether Meta has approved each one. The bot uses them whenever a buyer's last message is older than 24 hours.

Why. Without these, the bot cannot tell a buyer "payment verified" the next day. Today the merchant gets a note asking them to do it by hand. **Cost rule:** messages inside a buyer's 24-hour window are free, so everything that can be sent at once is sent at once. The confirmation tells the buyer to send "status" any time (free, because the buyer starts it). A paid message is never sent automatically: the order page shows "window closed, sending costs about Rs 1" with a button.

Done when: A message created from the portal shows as approved in Meta's tools, and a buyer who last wrote 25 hours ago still receives their confirmation. **Record the two review videos here.**

B3. Onboarding that checks before going live (2 weeks)

What we build. Today the "Go live" button just flips a switch. It becomes seven steps, each checked: shop details, connect WhatsApp, add at least one product, set delivery areas and charges (a screen that is missing today), choose COD on or off and add a bank account, choose the bot's name and greeting, and finally place a test order from your own phone. Two tick boxes at sign-up that Meta requires: no prohibited goods, and only message customers who contacted you first.

Why. A shop that goes live half set up produces wrong answers and bad reviews, which lowers its WhatsApp quality rating.

Done when: A new tester can only reach "live" by finishing all seven steps.

B4. What a real shop needs in its first week (2 weeks)

What we build. Alerts for new orders, payment claims and hand-overs that cost nothing: phone notifications from the portal itself (free, the default), WhatsApp to the merchant's personal number inside a free 24-hour window that the merchant opens by messaging their own shop number once and keeps open by replying, and email. If the window lapses, one message of about Rs 1 asks "reply OK to keep free alerts on" and nothing more is sent until they do. Order stages: packed, sent, delivered, with the buyer told at dispatch. Unpaid bank orders cancel themselves after 24 hours and the stock comes back. A customer who says "stop" is never messaged again (today the bot records it and keeps replying). Small fixes: delete a product, rename the bot, show today's figures in Pakistan time.

Why. These are the things a merchant notices on day one and judges the product by.

Done when: A tester places an order with the portal closed and gets a WhatsApp alert within a minute; a bank order with no screenshot is cancelled after 24 hours.

B5. Safe for many shops (1 to 2 weeks)

What we build. Error alerts to the owner's inbox when something breaks. A daily AI budget per shop so one busy shop cannot use up everyone's allowance. Limits on login attempts. A private owner-only page that lists all shops, their status and lets you suspend one. Tests that prove one shop can never see another shop's data.

Why. Today a problem in production is only found when someone complains.

Done when: A fake error in production reaches the owner's inbox within five minutes.

B6. Pilot with 3 to 5 real shops (2 to 3 weeks)

What we build. Real shops, real customers. Before approval they join as testers; after approval as normal accounts. One named person answers merchants on WhatsApp during Pakistan hours.

Why. Nothing replaces real buyers bargaining in real Roman Urdu.

Done when: 200 conversations and 30 orders with zero wrong prices, zero duplicate orders and zero data leaks between shops. Any of those three above zero pauses new sign-ups until fixed.

B7. Billing (1 to 2 weeks)

What we build. A 30-day free pilot, then a fixed monthly plan in rupees with a limit on conversations. A usage page. Invoices paid by bank transfer to our account and marked paid by hand. No payment gateway at first. A shop whose plan has run out switches to hand-over-only; it is never silently cut off.

Why. Charging comes last because the pilot tells us what to charge.

Done when: A shop on an expired plan still receives messages and the merchant sees why the bot stopped.

6. How long it takes

With one full-time engineer. Weeks on the calendar, not working days.

Milestone	Weeks	Finished by week
B1 Sign-up and Connect WhatsApp	3	3
B2 Pre-approved messages, then App Review sent	1	4
B3 Onboarding	2	6
B4 First-week needs	2	8
B5 Safe for many shops	1 to 2	10
B6 Pilot	2 to 3	13

Milestone	Weeks	Finished by week
B7 Billing	1 to 2	14

Meta's own waiting time fits inside weeks 1 to 6 if the paperwork lands this week. Every week the paperwork slips is a week later that real merchants can join, but the building work does not wait.

Decisions already made

Made so that nobody is waiting on them. Each can be changed, but each has a reason.

Decision	Reason
Merchants log in with email and password, not Facebook	Fewer things for Meta to review. The Connect WhatsApp button already handles the Facebook part.
One owner, one shop, one number per account	Team members and extra numbers come after billing.
Three pre-approved messages per shop, created automatically	Merchants should not have to write or submit templates.
Merchants pay Meta directly for conversations	As a Tech Provider we cannot carry their Meta bills.
Roman Urdu only at launch	It is the market. English and Urdu script can come later.
Our own subscription is paid by bank transfer at first	No gateway to integrate before we know the price.
Buyers pay by COD or bank transfer only	Nothing in the product ever touches buyer money.
Unpaid bank orders expire after 24 hours	Keeps stock honest.
Stock drops when an order is placed, returns on cancellation	What the code does now; merchants edit stock for sales made elsewhere.
Prohibited-goods and opt-in tick boxes at sign-up	Meta's rules; enforced by suspension, not by reading every catalog.
No paid WhatsApp message is ever sent automatically	Free channels first (portal notifications, email, the buyer asking). A paid message only when the merchant presses a button that shows the price.

Keeping WhatsApp costs near zero

The rule WhatsApp uses. When a buyer messages a shop, a 24-hour window opens. Anything the bot sends inside it is free. After it closes, only pre-approved messages can be sent, and each costs the merchant about Rs 1 (Meta's Pakistan utility rate; check the current rate card).
So the product is built to stay inside free windows. Buyer messages go out immediately. The buyer is told to send "status" to check an order, which is free. Merchant alerts use the portal's own phone notifications and email, and WhatsApp alerts ride on a window the merchant keeps open by replying. A typical shop's WhatsApp bill should be a few rupees a month.
Sahulatcart pays Meta nothing. Under the Tech Provider model only merchants pay for messages. Our costs are hosting and the AI, which the cheapest Gemini model and a daily budget per shop keep small.

7. What only the owner can do

Everything here is on Track A. Nothing on Track B needs it, but Meta's clock does not start until it exists.

Item	Why Meta needs it
Company registration certificate and FBR NTN certificate (clear scans, all four corners visible)	The two documents Meta accepts to prove the name and address.
The legal name copied letter for letter from the certificate	"(Pvt) Ltd" and "(Private) Limited" count as different names to a reviewer.
The full registered street address	"Lahore, Pakistan" is a city, not an address.
A utility bill or bank statement showing the business phone number	Proves the phone number.
Gemini billing switched on in Google Cloud	The free tier learns from buyer data, which breaks WhatsApp's rules. It also allows only 20 requests a day.
A dedicated SIM that has never been used on WhatsApp	Becomes our own official number.
A card on the Meta business account, and two-step login on the Meta account	Meta requires both.
Later: submit business verification (A3), accept the Tech Provider terms (A5), click submit on App Review (A6), and choose the 3 to 5 pilot shops	These need the account holder.

What was dropped from the old plan

Seven different numbering systems for the same work. This plan has 7 Meta steps and 7 milestones.
Meta's review scheduled after weeks of internal rework. It is now sent at week 4.
Big engineering projects before launch (message queues, key rotation, deletion pipelines, restore drills). They come when there is load to justify them.
Facebook login for the portal. See the decisions table.
An estimate of 37 to 64 working days. It was about half of the truth; this plan is in weeks.

Glossary

Term	Plain meaning
Meta	The company that owns WhatsApp and Facebook.
Tech Provider	Meta's name for a company like us that connects other businesses to WhatsApp through its own software.
Business verification	Meta checking that Nubrix Technologies is a real registered company, using documents.
App Review	Meta checking what our software does, using videos, before letting it work for any business.
Advanced access	Permission to use WhatsApp's tools for other businesses, not only our own.
Embedded Signup / "Connect WhatsApp"	Meta's pop-up window where a merchant links their WhatsApp Business number to our software with a few clicks.
Tester	A person Meta lets us add to our app so they can use it before approval.
Key / token	A long secret code that lets our software send messages as a merchant. One per shop, stored encrypted.
Template / pre-approved message	A message Meta has approved in advance. The only kind that can be sent to a buyer who last wrote more than 24 hours ago.
24-hour window	After a buyer messages, the bot may reply freely for 24 hours. After that, only templates.
Webhook	The way WhatsApp delivers incoming messages to our server.
Display name	The business name a buyer sees on WhatsApp. Meta approves it separately and it must match the real business.
Quality rating	Meta's green / yellow / red score for a number, based on blocks and reports. Red means restrictions.
Pilot	The first 3 to 5 real shops using the product with real customers before we open it to everyone.